







Captain America gained an African-American partner, the Falcon, only one year on from Martin Luther King's assassination.

CAN YOU DIG IT?

Andy Diggle talks about writing Captain America: Living Legend



On Captain America's character:
Simple decency and rugged self-reliance pretty much sums it up. I'd say he has much in common with Superman – that sense of humble, good old-fashioned decency.

On what Captain America represents:
The notion of fairness, the idea that anyone can succeed if they work hard and play fair, goes right to the heart of the American Dream, and I think Cap embodies that. The fact that he was just an ordinary Joe who signed up, and ended up becoming this paragon. True or not, I think that's how America likes to see itself.

On writing Captain America:
I have a problem with jingoistic nationalism, from whatever country, and I was aware that could be a problem. That's one of the reasons I cooked up a story where "My country, right or wrong" wouldn't be an issue.

On American politics:
I deliberately avoided them. If you want to write a story about the nature of American nationalism, a comic called *Captain America* probably isn't the best place to do it – not without pissing off the fan base, at least.

On the reasons for Cap's continued success:
Jack and Stan.

On the role of nostalgia:
The 'man out of time' aspect has been central to the character since his 'rebirth' in the Sixties, so nostalgia is an inherent part of what makes him tick – more so than most other decades-old characters. I tried to reflect that in the story itself, in the flashbacks sections, rather than have it be something he dwells on himself.

Captain America: Living Legend is ongoing from Marvel Comics. Pick it up from all good comic stores or digitally via the Comixology app.





approach to the events: "His attitude was both responsive and responsible, promising to take the fight to the enemy, but being very careful to know who that enemy was… he prevented a grieving man from attacking a random Middle Eastern man on the street, telling him 'he's not the enemy.'"

Post 9/11, Captain America found himself balanced uneasily between pro and anti-war factions, unwilling to be claimed by either one. "9/11 and the War on Terror was tricky," says Dittmer. "They tried to engage with the context of Islamic terrorism without resorting to anti-Islamic caricatures, and they tried to 'balance' it by talking about how it was blowback for American foreign policy."

During the war in Afghanistan, the motives behind American participation were questioned vigorously, in contrast with the mostly pro-action consensus for World War II. Marvel took those themes and created the acclaimed *Civil War* arc, which pitted Iron Man and Captain America against each other over the Superhuman Registration Act, a thinly veiled allusion to the Patriot Act. Once again, Cap showed that he was no tool of the status quo, mounting an opposition to this threat to liberty, which ultimately led to his murder. Whether the death is seen as symbolic of the death of American ideals or of patriotic identity, the story is a powerful one, and news of his demise was picked up by the mainstream press. In true comic-book style, however, Cap came back right when the world needed him most, and since then has continued to apply his high ideals to a flawed world.

According to Dittmer, "The trick for the writers is to keep Captain America in touch with contemporary values while nevertheless making it seem like he never changes. In truth, this is the challenge of the nation-state – pretending there is some fundamental essence that links all these people and things together throughout time." In other words, what keeps *Captain America* relevant is tied in with America's own changing ideas of itself as a country and an identity. Backed by a multi-million dollar publishing company and a sense of nostalgic regret, *Captain America* couldn't help but find renewed success, and yet ultimately he has endured simply because he has managed to encapsulate America – flaws and all – for the world. As long as the American dream has a hold on popular culture, Cap isn't going anywhere.

Many of the comics mentioned here are available digitally from Comixlology or Marvel Unlimited, and we urge you to check them out!